

DETERMINED: Mayawati is following through on her election promises



MAYA'S TARGETS

DADUA: The dreaded bandit was gunned down along with nine of his gang members by an STF team in the forests of Chitrakoot district, after a 27-year-long hunt.

MUKHTAR ANSARI: The mafia don-turned-MLA, an ally of SP who ruled the roost in the Ghazipur jail, has been raided. His fish pond in the jail has been demolished.

ATIQ AHMED: The gangster SP MP has been declared an absconder. He is wanted by police in the murder of a BSP MLA. His economic empire in Allahabad has been bulldozed.

UDAI PRATAP SINGH: The history sheet of the father of former minister 'Raja Bhaiya' has been reopened.

Photographs by MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



state's jails had turned into safe sanctuaries for powerful criminals. During the previous regime, a senior police officer had written to the government complaining that call girls from Delhi frequented the district jail. The complaint was ignored.

The case files of gangster SP MP Atiq Ahmed and Uday Pratap Singh, father of notorious gangster and former minister Raghuraj Pratap Singh or Raja Bhaiya, were also closed and their gangs declared "inactive". Filing FIRs or chargesheets against those the ruling

party wished to protect was impossible.

Mayawati has gone after such *dadoos* with a deliberate single-mindedness. In her previous regime, she had slapped 136 cases against Mulayam Singh in a single day for the alleged misuse of his discretionary quota. This time she spared her adversary but passed an order that the police should register criminal cases against all those who enjoyed immunity in the past three-and-a-half years.

The police, says Director-General of Police Vikram Singh, have lodged 2,500

FIRs in the past 25 days against various people including MPs, MLAs and workers of the SP. Ansari's fish pond has been demolished, and the economic empire built by Ahmed and his brother Ashraf is being razed brick by brick.

The administration of the state's jails has, for the first time in its history, been handed over to the Police Department. Simultaneous raids, led by DIG (jail) Pramod Tewari, were launched on the three most sensitive jails in Ghazipur, Varanasi and Naini. Tewari discovered and demolished the pond in Ghazipur Jail. Police also discovered that explosives and ammunition were accessible in most jails.

Half a dozen jail officials have been suspended, while the monitoring of inmates has been intensified with CCTVs, mobile phone jammers, two-layer frisking and a ban on mobile phone usage inside the barracks. Ahmed's case file has been re-opened and a township proposed by a member of his family, called Alena City, was demolished by the Allahabad Police.

Like Ahmed, the family of Raja Bhaiya is also facing the heat again. His father's history sheet has been reopened and a dozen FIRs have been lodged against his supporters. Allahabad DIG Vijay Kumar said Ahmed, who is wanted in the case of murder of BSP MLA Raju Pal, has been declared absconder. The chief minister has also ordered a special investigation into the multi-crore food scam that took place when Raja Bhaiya was food minister. Former minister Azam Khan is also facing criminal cases and the walls of his pet project, Jauhar University in Rampur, now stand demolished.

Unlike in her previous regime, this time Mayawati has given key positions to upright police officers. She has ordered Cabinet Secretary Shashank Shekhar Singh to personally supervise the crime situation in the state which has—by rough estimate—600 mafia gangs, 100 dacoit gangs and more than 150 MLAs with a criminal background.

Tackling criminality, which has completely seeped into the state's polity, needs political will. For now, Mayawati is determined to show that she lacks none of it.

with Sunil Rai